

Pathways for Educators to Challenge Deficit Perspectives: Adolescents' Transnational Digital Literacy Practices in the Classroom

Maneka Deanna Brooks, Katherine K. Frankel

In our professional and personal lives, we have seen how certain adolescents identified as English learners (ELs) and struggling readers are positioned as having limited literacy abilities (Brooks, 2016; Frankel, 2017). Moreover, we have observed that common instructional settings for adolescents identified as ELs are compulsory reading intervention courses that specifically identify these students as struggling readers, with all the deficit perspectives that accompany this label (e.g., Brooks, 2019; Callahan, 2006; Frankel & Brooks, 2018; Gomez, 2004; Wu & Coady, 2010). We are concerned that these intersecting labels and instructional settings can serve to mask the linguistic and literate abilities of this student population.

In our final column for our coedited *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy* (JAAL) department, we focus on those students to whom both the EL label and the struggling reader label have been applied. This focus reflects our ongoing concern with the negative consequences of labeling and our commitment to challenging deficit perspectives about so-called struggling readers. Here, we use a selection of articles published in JAAL to show how adolescents' social media and other digital literacy practices can provide a pathway for educators to build on students' transnational knowledge bases. Previously, we argued that this type of instruction is fundamental to challenging deficit notions that are inherent to the struggling reader label (Frankel & Brooks, 2018).

The Importance of Building on Adolescents' Digital Literacy Practices

Intentionally creating space for adolescents' social media and other digital literacy practices requires

recognizing that literacy instruction is more than teaching isolated and discrete skills (Aguilera & Lopez, 2020; O'Byrne, 2019; Stornaiuolo, & Thomas, 2018). Drawing on Frankel, Becker, Rowe, and Pearson's (2016) definition of literacy, we conceptualize "literacy as the process of using reading, writing, and oral language to extract, construct, integrate, and critique meaning through interaction and involvement with multimodal texts in the context of socially situated practices" (p. 7).

Theoretically, this more robust definition highlights that literacy practices are active, socially situated, and multimodal. Practically, this means that literacy cannot solely be measured by metrics such as standardized English or reading test scores or the number of books one has read. Instead, this definition requires recognizing the multitude of ways that adolescents use literacy in their daily lives (e.g., for leisure, information, communication, and work), which can be an important source of information for in-school literacy instruction. Therefore, we situate this column within the broader research that has recognized the complexities of adolescents' digital literacy practices as a productive space for literacy instruction (Alvermann, 2008; Lam, 2012; Lewis Ellison, 2017).

Literacy instruction that draws on social media and other digital communication practices is a way for educators to honor adolescents' literacies in formal literacy instruction (Li, 2017). The importance of social media extends across multiple demographic groups and serves multiple purposes (Lam & Warriner, 2012; McArthur, 2016; Stewart, 2014). For instance, three articles in JAAL highlighted how refugee youth use social media to maintain familial, community, and cultural connections (Dávila, 2015; Gilhooly & Lee, 2014; Omerbašić, 2015).

For example, Gilhooly and Lee (2014) showed how three Karen brothers used social media to learn about information that could help their family. They learned and

shared with others how to file taxes, get their driver's licenses, and access other public resources. In Omerbašić's (2015) study, eight adolescent refugee students from various ethnic communities from the Thailand–Burma border used social media to create translocal digital spaces where official geographical, cultural, and linguistic boundaries were shattered to reflect their multidimensional experiences. For instance, one of the teenage girls learned a Karen love song through YouTube that was subtitled in Karen using a Romanized orthography. Through this digital literacy practice that integrated the Romanized expression of Karen, Omerbašić argued that this young person was able to bridge her pre- and post-resettlement life. Finally, one of the participants in Dávila's (2015) study, a resettled refugee from Somalia, used the Facebook page BBC Somalia to learn about news from her home country. In this way, she shared that she was able to maintain a connection to life in Somalia, which was an important part of her identity.

Digital Literacies Sustain Transnational Connections

The types of literacy practices in which the youth in the aforementioned studies engaged demonstrate important aspects of their literacy knowledge that might otherwise have remained hidden in school. They also highlight how youth who have had to flee their home communities cultivate complex transnational connections. Distinct from traditional understandings of transnational students as individuals who live, study, and work across multiple countries, these adolescents employed digital connections to maintain transnational knowledge and communities within contexts where they were unlikely to be able to return (Skerrett, 2019; Zúñiga & Hamann, 2009).

Skerrett (2019) noted that transnational knowledge is often overlooked in literacy classrooms. She argued that very few literacy scholars have sought to explicitly build on transnational knowledge—an article in *JAAL* by Jiménez, Smith, and Teague (2009) is one notable exception—despite this knowledge being a powerful tool for reaching students who are often overlooked in academic spaces. Skerrett offered three fundamental dimensions of transnationally inclusive literacy education:

1. Educators learning with students about their socio-cultural, linguistic, literate, and educational experiences across local and transnational settings
2. Educators using this information to guide development of curricula and pedagogies that respond to

students' life histories, educational experiences, and academic development

3. Educators collaborating with students to document and communicate about students' academic development to other educational stakeholders

We contend that building on students' digital literacy practices in the classroom is an example of transnationally inclusive literacy education. Yet, we also acknowledge the challenges inherent to this approach. Specifically, as noted by Haddix and Sealey-Ruiz (2012), digital literacies can be viewed as threatening and a distraction from academic tasks, particularly among youth from minoritized racial backgrounds. Next, we speak back to the framing of minoritized youth's digital literacy practices as illicit and reframe these tools as instructionally generative.

Recommendations for Leveraging Digital (Inter)Connections in Classrooms

Building on adolescents' digital literacy practices requires that educators learn with and from their students. Each of the three *JAAL* articles introduced earlier provided insights about how to do this in authentic and sustainable ways. For example, Dávila (2015) wrote, "Explore with your students their reading preferences (types of texts, how often, when, and where they prefer to read)" (p. 648). Although not explicitly digital, this type of expansive exploration of literacy is an important step in highlighting that all texts, including digital texts, count as tools for meaningful literacy engagement. Gilhooly and Lee (2014) further encouraged educators to have conversations with their students about how and why they use the internet at home, as an opportunity to develop understandings about students' digital practices. Gilhooly and Lee noted that such conversations also can shed light on whether students have regular access to the internet. Omerbašić (2015) encouraged educators to explicitly ask students to share examples of their digital media practices so educators will have concrete examples to inform their instruction.

Projects that center students' digital literacy practices can create opportunities for students to bring their personal lives into the classroom in meaningful ways. Using Gilhooly and Lee's (2014) article as an example, if an educator knew that youth in her classroom were adept at compiling resources digitally to create informational sources for others, she might then incorporate this digital practice to support students in identifying

an issue and using digital technology to learn about and communicate information to multiple distinct audiences. As another example, an educator who worked with the young people in Omerbašić's (2015) study might use songs that students shared on social media to study literary devices. Finally, an educator who had a focal student from Dávila's (2015) study in the classroom might recognize that reading about Somalia online was an important digital literacy practice that related to the study of current events. Importantly, there does not need to be a one-to-one connection between a student's digital practices and an academic assignment. However, it helps if assignments are open enough that there is ample space for students to bring their digital literacy repertoires to bear.

A Caveat: Privacy, Risk, and Vulnerability

Although adolescents' digital literacy practices can provide an authentic way for educators to engage youth's transnational knowledge, bringing them into the classroom may create a space of risk for students and their families. That is, young people who are at the intersection of multiple labels (i.e., EL and struggling reader) within their school systems may also have other societal labels that impact their lives in pivotal ways. For instance, students' and their families' immigration status and understandings of the safety of the school environments may impact their willingness to share certain aspects of their background in school settings (Jefferies & Dabach, 2015; Kleyn, Alulema, Khalifa, & Morales Romero, 2018). Therefore, it is essential that educators are aware of, and reflexive about, the potential vulnerabilities of their students and their students' families.

As one example, Noguerón-Liu (2017) documented how certain adult immigrants in her work refused to participate in social media activities or post photographs of family members because of privacy concerns. Although not all participants felt the same about privacy, Noguerón-Liu emphasized the need for educators—who occupy positions of power in their classrooms—to never assume shared understandings and to have ongoing discussions about privacy and risk with students. For adolescents, such discussions can have the added benefit of supporting youth to consider the consequences of sharing information publicly on social media and other digital platforms.

Johnson and Kendrick (2017) offered one way for educators to navigate these important issues. In their study of digital storytelling in a class of high school refugee and immigrant youth, the authors showed how creating

a digital story around the broad topic of accomplishment allowed for varying levels of vulnerability among students. Whereas the focal student, an Iraqi refugee named Yaqub, used the assignment to narrate his experience as a refugee, other classmates chose different kinds of accomplishments that may have required less vulnerability (e.g., learning to cook). In this case, the topic of accomplishment provided students with multiple points of access and the opportunity to decide the extent to which they shared personal information.

Concluding Thoughts

In this column, we argued that building on adolescents' social media and other digital literacy practices is one way for educators to sustain transnational connections in literacy instruction. Drawing from recent JAAL articles, we offered recommendations (and some cautions) for how literacy educators can leverage digital interconnections in classrooms. We hope that these ideas will support educators in troubling and disrupting the dual labels of EL and struggling reader and in reimagining instructional settings to honor the linguistic and literacy practices of their students.

REFERENCES

- Aguilera, E., & Lopez, G. (2020). Centering first-generation college students' lived experiences through critical digital storytelling. *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 63(5), 583–587. <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaal.1037>.
- Alvermann, D.E. (2008). Why bother theorizing adolescents' online literacies for classroom practice and research? *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 52(1), 8–19. <https://doi.org/10.1598/JAAL.52.1.2>
- Brooks, M.D. (2016). Notes and talk: An examination of a long-term English learner reading-to-learn in a high school biology classroom. *Language and Education*, 30(3), 235–251. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09500782.2015.1102275>
- Brooks, M.D. (2019). A mother's advocacy: Lessons for educators of long-term EL students. In H.A. Linville & J. Whiting (Eds.), *Advocacy in English language teaching and learning* (pp. 175–189). New York, NY: Routledge.
- Callahan, R.M. (2006). The intersection of accountability and language: Can reading intervention replace English language development? *Bilingual Research Journal*, 30(1), 1–21. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15235882.2006.10162863>
- Dávila, L.T. (2015). Diaspora literacies: An exploration of what reading means to young African immigrant women. *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 58(8), 641–649. <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaal.414>
- Frankel, K.K. (2017). What does it mean to be a reader? Identity and positioning in two high school literacy intervention classes. *Reading & Writing Quarterly*, 33(6), 501–518. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10573569.2016.1250143>
- Frankel, K.K., Becker, B.L.C., Rowe, M.W., & Pearson, P.D. (2016). From “what is reading?” to what is literacy? *Journal*

- of Education, 196(3), 7–17. <https://doi.org/10.1177/002205741619600303>
- Frankel, K.K., & Brooks, M.D. (2018). Why the “struggling reader” label is harmful (and what educators can do about it). *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 62(1), 111–114. <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaal.758>
- Gilhooly, D., & Lee, E. (2014). The role of digital literacy practices on refugee resettlement: The case of three Karen brothers. *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 57(5), 387–396. <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaal.254>
- Gomez, M.L. (2004). Textual tactics of identification. *Anthropology & Education Quarterly*, 35(4), 391–410. <https://doi.org/10.1525/aeq.2004.35.4.391>
- Haddix, M., & Sealey-Ruiz, Y. (2012). Cultivating digital and popular literacies as empowering and emancipatory acts among urban youth. *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 56(3), 189–192. <https://doi.org/10.1002/JAAL.00126>
- Jefferies, J., & Dabach, D.B. (2015). Breaking the silence: Facing undocumented issues in teacher practice. *Association of Mexican American Educators Journal*, 8(1), 83–93.
- Jiménez, R.T., Smith, P.H., & Teague, B.L. (2009). Transnational and community literacies for teachers. *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 53(1), 16–26. <https://doi.org/10.1598/JAAL.53.1.2>
- Johnson, L., & Kendrick, M. (2017). “Impossible is nothing”: Expressing difficult knowledge through digital storytelling. *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 60(6), 667–675. <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaal.624>
- Kleyn, T., Alulema, D., Khalifa, F., & Morales Romero, A. (2018). Learning from undocumented students: Testimonios for strategies to support and resist. *New Educator*, 14(1), 24–41. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1547688X.2017.1404174>
- Lam, W.S.E. (2012). What immigrant students can teach us about new media literacy. *Phi Delta Kappan*, 94(4), 62–65. <https://doi.org/10.1177/003172171209400416>
- Lam, W.S.E., & Warriner, D.S. (2012). Transnationalism and literacy: Investigating the mobility of people, languages, texts, and practices in contexts of migration. *Reading Research Quarterly*, 47(2), 191–215. <https://doi.org/10.1002/RRQ.016>
- Lewis Ellison, T. (2017). Digital participation, agency, and choice: An African American youth’s digital storytelling about Minecraft. *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 61(1), 25–35. <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaal.645>
- Li, G. (2017). From absence to affordances: Integrating old and new literacies in school-based instruction for English learners. *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 61(3), 241–246. <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaal.662>
- McArthur, S.A. (2016). Black girls and critical media literacy for social activism. *English Education*, 48(4), 462–479.
- Noguérón-Liu, S. (2017). “Everybody knows your business”/“Todo mundo se da cuenta”: Immigrant adults’ construction of privacy, risk, and vulnerability in online platforms. *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 60(5), 505–513. <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaal.599>
- O’Byrne, W.I. (2019). Educate, empower, advocate: Amplifying marginalized voices in a digital society. *Contemporary Issues in Technology and Teacher Education*, 19(4). Retrieved from <https://www.citejournal.org/volume-19/issue-4-19/english-language-arts/educate-empower-advocate-amplifying-marginalized-voices-in-a-digital-society/>
- Omerbašić, D. (2015). Literacy as a translocal practice: Digital multimodal literacy practices among girls resettled as refugees. *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy*, 58(6), 472–481. <https://doi.org/10.1002/jaal.389>
- Skerrett, A. (2019). Advancing theoretical perspectives on transnationalism in literacy research. In D.E. Alvermann, N.J. Unrau, & M. Sailors (Eds.), *Theoretical models and processes of literacy* (7th ed., pp. 497–513). New York, NY: Routledge.
- Stewart, M.A. (2014). Social networking, workplace, and entertainment literacies: The out-of-school literate lives of newcomer adolescent immigrants. *Literacy Research and Instruction*, 53(4), 347–371. <https://doi.org/10.1080/19388071.2014.931495>
- Stornaiuolo, A., & Thomas, E.E. (2018). Restorying as political action: Authoring resistance through youth media arts. *Learning, Media and Technology*, 43(4), 345–358. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17439884.2018.1498354>
- Wu, C., & Coady, M.R. (2010). ‘The United States is America?’: A cultural perspective on READ 180 materials. *Language, Culture and Curriculum*, 23(2), 153–165. <https://doi.org/10.1080/07908318.2010.494732>
- Zúñiga, V., & Hamann, E.T. (2009). Sojourners in Mexico with U.S. school experience: A new taxonomy for transnational students. *Comparative Education Review*, 53(3), 329–353. <https://doi.org/10.1086/599356>

The department editors welcome reader comments.



KATHERINE K. FRANKEL is an assistant professor of literacy education in the Wheelock College of Education & Human Development at Boston University, MA, USA; email kfrankel@bu.edu.



MANEKA DEANNA BROOKS is an assistant professor of reading education in the Department of Curriculum and Instruction at Texas State University, San Marcos, USA; email maneka@txstate.edu.